I was impatient to be there myself, to feel the energy, to walk with others, to hear the sounds and to test my own endurance.

I spent two nights and two days with the Yatra, and the journey began as soon as I alighted at the Sawai Madhopur train station. A young doctor, one of the national yatris, had come to town to collect medicines needed at the camp, but was stranded and needed to get back to the camp about 20 kilometres away. As we chatted during the lift I was able to offer him, I asked him the many questions I had arrived with. He had left behind his wife and two children to come on the Yatra because he was deeply worried about the direction the country was going in and wanted badly to be part of something positive. This was the gist of what many other people also said to me, and each had their own story of why they were walking. No lofty ideological statements, but simple ones such as ‘We can do better than hate’ or ‘I just had to do this myself as the Yatra has such a good message’ or ‘In our country, walking as tapasya is something we all understand’. I met more than one young woman who had run away from home to join the Yatra after catching a glimpse of it passing through her state. Women walked in crisp saris, men in the same clothes day after day—the variety of languages, backgrounds and temperaments, the whole experience was mind-boggling. Over the two days, I met several other professionals such as me, who had all joined in solidarity and wanted to experience the Yatra first-hand. It was a mini India that seemed to be on the march. We all know this India exists, but rarely get to experience it first-hand all at once.

Why the march? As Rahul himself explained, the streets are the only arena left for India’s Opposition. That is, in an India where the Modi government has weaponized the police, the courts, and tax and other enforcement institutions to hound any critic;[1] and where big businesses compete to join the elite ranks of Modi’s billionaire crony capitalists[2] and the mainstream media has become a crony-owned post-truth foghorn for the regime.[3] Marching en mass is the only way to make visible the fact that many disagree with the ruinous direction the government is taking India in. Predictably, the Yatra was ignored by most of the mainstream media. Consequently, most Indians even slightly away from its route, as well as the